

Nightjars and frogmouths

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Caprimulgiformes
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	123

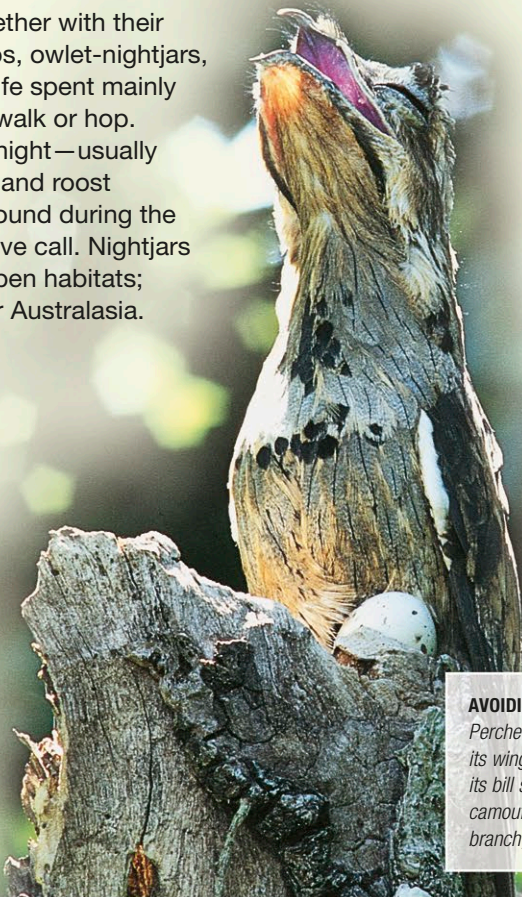
These long-winged birds, together with their relatives, the nighthawks, potoos, owlet-nightjars, and oilbirds, are adapted for a life spent mainly in the air; indeed, most cannot walk or hop. They hunt at dusk, dawn, or at night—usually capturing insects on the wing—and roost motionless in trees or on the ground during the day. Many species are known for their loud, distinctive call. Nightjars occur almost throughout the world, in forests and open habitats; their relatives are restricted to the Americas, Asia, or Australasia.

Anatomy

Nightjars and their relatives are round-bodied birds, with a large head and short neck. They have a remarkably large mouth, with an extremely wide gape for trapping insects. Most species have long tails and elongated wings that are ideal for flying swiftly with rapid changes of direction in pursuit of food. Except for owlet-nightjars, these birds have short legs and weak, tiny feet that are unsuitable for walking. Birds in this group usually have brown or gray, cryptically patterned plumage.



WIDE GAPE
The bill of nightjars and their relatives (here, a red-necked nightjar) is almost as broad as their head and can be opened very wide. In nightjars, this makes an effective trap for flying insects, which are caught in midair, one at a time.



Feeding

Most of the birds in this group feed primarily on insects, which they catch in midair; alternatively, they may swoop down to take them from the ground. Many species fly continually, while others (such as the potoo) make brief but regular sorties from a perch. Frogmouths feed on other birds, mammals, and amphibians, as well as insects. Oilbirds eat only fruit.



BRISTLES
Nightjars (here, the European nightjar) and some of their relatives are equipped with a set of bristles around the edge of their bills. These bristles may be sensitive to touch, and in some species help filter insects into the mouth.

AVOIDING DETECTION
Perched on an upright branch, the common potoo flattens its wings against its body and points its head upward with its bill slightly open. This stance, combined with the camouflage coloring, makes the bird resemble a broken branch, providing protection against predators.

Steatornis caripensis

Oilbird



Location N. and C. South America

Length 16–19 1/2 in (40–49 cm)
Weight 13–17 oz (350–475 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



The oilbird is a unique species—the only nocturnal fruit-eating bird in the world. During the day, it remains deep inside caves, sometimes 2 1/2 mile (1 km) underground. It leaves the cave at night and may travel over 45 miles (75 km) in search of food. Oilbirds use sight and possibly smell to locate the fruit of trees such as laurels and palms, swooping down and plucking them from branches.

LARGE-MOUTHED BIRD
The reddish brown oilbird has white spots on the head, throat, and wings. Its large mouth enables it to carry plenty of food back to the young in the nest—a mound of mud, feces, rotten fruit, and seeds.



ECHOLOCATION



The oilbird nests and roosts in large colonies in caves. It uses echolocation to find its way in the dark; the signals it produces are relatively low-pitched and sound like “clicks” to the human ear. Birds also call to one another to stay in touch, filling the cave with their loud, harsh cries.

Podargus strigoides

Tawny frogmouth



Location S. New Guinea, Australia (including Tasmania)

Length 13 1/4–21 in (34–53 cm)
Weight 6–24 oz (175–675 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Frogmouths look similar to nightjars, but instead of hunting nocturnal insects on the wing, they pounce on small animals and larger insects on the ground. The tawny frogmouth's large eyes help it to see well in the dark, and it flies through its territory at night, stopping at suitable foraging perches and watching for prey to move nearby. When necessary, it will beat larger animals to death before swallowing them. This species lives in pairs or family groups, and the birds call frequently to maintain contact over the large territory in which they feed and breed. The nest is a simple platform of sticks, placed in the fork of a tree.



large head
stocky body

CAMOUFLAGE
The tawny frogmouth's red- or brown-mottled gray plumage blends in with the color of branches of trees and bushes.

short legs

DEFENSE POSTURE



If threatened, the tawny frogmouth stands erect, looking like a broken branch on a tree. This posture may sometimes be accompanied by a gaping display in which the bird opens its large, wide mouth.